You call down the Thunder

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55779607.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, F/M

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
IN SPACE!, catradora, sci fi, Drama, Angst, Action, romance (PINING), Pining, battles, Guns, Violence, Humour, Action/Adventure, Adult Language

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by Jezmatron

Summary

The Horde has dealt a blow to the Resistance. They occupied their station, have seized Adora's ship and have driven the battered collection of pirates, miners, merchants and civilians to the brink.

But Adora has a plan to get her ship back.

It's insane. It's poorly thought out. It's borderline suicidal.

But Adora only has one tried and tested way of expressing her emotions... and it seems to have worked so far.

Notes

SPACE.

CAPTAIN.

CATRAAAAAAAAAA!

We're back folks, with another installment. Should be a shorter, more action packed one here. Adora answering the call. Let's see how this allll plays out.

Chapter 1

The command deck of the freighter was cramped, normally. But now, with the vessel nestled in an alcove of a chunk of the shattered planetoid and the crew and refugees exploring the oddly habitable ruins of the area,, it was oddly spacious. Consoles glowed green in the low emergency lighting and cast a sickly light across Angella's face as she stared at the tiny map before her. Her wings, gossamer and almost translucent, flexed, while her pastel jumpsuit seemed ghostly in the dimness of the bridge.

"Mom?"

Angella startled and glanced over at the hatch that led to the command deck. Glimmer stood there, a pensive look on her face. The taller woman brushed her long hair back as she regarded her daughter with a wan smile, "Glimmer. You startled me, darling."

"I wanted to update you on the, um… exploration. Adora's charts are scarily accurate. We've mapped out entryways into the nebula and, well, we've gone only a bit into the ruins here. Plenty of space. And the sensor mapping is going well, even if we've just started."

Angella nodded slowly and looked out through the viewport. Outside was a strange dichotomous view: the barely visible void of space, obscured by a rocky overhand and, beyond that, the wispy greens and blues of gas-clouds and debris. Through that inky soup, floating rocks and distant segments of the former planet could be spied, before the colour became dense and obscured vision, leaving only faint glittering points of black.

Around the freighter were the various ships of their "fleet" - shuttles and cargo haulers; passenger ships and "decommissioned" frigates with barely a gun to their name. Out in the expanse, more ships could be seen, moving between closer chunks of planetoid, which seemed oddly locked in position with their current roost. The whole place had a sense of wrongness to it. But necessity was their byword.

"That is what troubles me, darling. This place feels… wrong."

"The ruined remains of a once habitable world that shattered only a few decades ago with no record of it happening?" Glimmer smirked, but there was nervousness in her face as she spoke, "That has probably miles of weirdly geometric and neatly designed corridors from an unknown civilisation and strangely functional technology? That place?"

Glimmer's smile was a bit too brittle and Angella arched an eyebrow, "Glimmer?"

"Yeah, it's CREEPY as hell, mom. But we don't have a choice, do we?"

The pair sagged and let out morose chuckles at the same time. Angella turned her gaze back to the simple map, projected up from the small holo-display, "So much like your father. Able to see the humour in the most unlikely of situations."

Glimmer stepped forward and placed a hand on her mother's back, "Hey, mom. It's ok. We're all ok. And we're safe. If… a bit rattled?"

"For how long, I wonder," Angella bit her lip and shook her head, "I shouldn't fret. You don't need to hear…"

"Mom, I do. We're all in this. You kept us safe for a long time. And with the sensor masking Mermista is doing…."

"Did I? We lost our home, Glimmer. We picked a fight with a monster and we lost. I'm putting a brave face on but I am… wondering if this is a solution."

Glimmer studied her mother, "Are you still blaming Adora?"

The taller woman opened her mouth then chuckled and shook her head, "No… no not at all. I'm blaming myself. I forced that girl back into this. If anyone is responsible… it's me. I had hoped… but I did not reckon with such a capable enemy. And now I am afraid it is but a matter of time until they come for us once more. Even with our solutions."

"But this time we'll be better prepared, better equipped!" Glimmer folded her arms, but her face was tight with worry, "We have to be."

“My darling, with what? Granted, this bastion is… defensible. Hard to find. But the enemy has time and an established foothold. We need food, water, supplies. We have no army, no reinforcements. I say this not to… not to make you despair. But perhaps I should face the inevitable. All that matters is keeping our people safe. And getting them out of this trap.”

“Give up the fight?” Glimmer sounded shocked.

“Sometimes it is more valorous to step away. To pick a new battlefield. This place…”

“Is our HOME. Where else can we go? We go to another empty system, it’s just a matter of time before the Empire, the *Horde* turns up there too. Stronger. We give and we give and we give, mom. We die by… by inches.”

Angella swallowed and closed her eyes, “I just don’t want to…”

Glimmer’s hug rocked her mother, “You won’t lose *me* mom. Not if we work together. Not if we PLAN. Adora will help. We just need time to think. To work it out. You’ll see.”

Angella sighed and folded her arms around the smaller woman. For a moment, she allowed herself to relax. Motion caught her eye and she watched Huntara’s corvette drift out of the void and angle

to land on a bare strip of the smooth stone that composed the shard they were hiding on.

Glimmer pulled away and let out a relieved breath as the bay door of the vessel opened, allowing the small crew to emerge. Huntara came first, leading a large lizard man, who had an arm over her shoulder. He seemed to be more bruised than seriously hurt. Behind them came Lonnie and a small, wiry man, with finally Adora and the rest of Huntara's skeleton crew.

"I suppose we should go meet our new arrivals," Angella mused. She looked down at her daughter and blew out a breath then laughed, "You are right, darling. Forgive an old woman her moments of doubt. Adora's sensor plan. This place… it will work. It has to. You are right. It will be a new bastion. For what other choices do we have?" Glimmer smiled up at her, then released her and nodded, before the pair exited the bridge.

It didn't take long to exit the freighter and they moved to join the gathering. Other refugees and station members had arrived, taking a pause from working on their ships, or returning from the caverns of the rocky shard. Adora had remained on the ramp of the vessel and appeared to be searching the crowd.

The gathering wasn't hostile: mostly just curious and a little suspicious of the new, former Horde members. A few questions were yelled out, some accusations as well. Many recognised Kyle, and some knew Lonnie at a glance. But it was Huntara who quelled the shouts.

“Get back, idiots. These boys got spaced. Give ‘em room, give ‘em ROOM. Not every day you survive your execution.”

That got the crowd to clam up, the murmurs becoming far less heated. Glimmer let out a breath and glanced at her mother. Angella studied the trio, then looked up towards Adora, who ignored them as she continued to search the group. The blonde seemed to notice someone and hopped from the ramp and disappeared from view.

The trio were led to Angella, who gave them a once over, then looked to Huntara, “All went well then?”

“Aye. Though this lot don’t reckon they’re stopping. Want to get far away.”

The tall woman nodded slowly, then regarded the bedraggled trio, “Cannot say that I blame you. We will be offering opportunities for those who wish to leave; we have to be cautious as I am sure you can imagine. Until then, we will need your support. And… and intelligence you can provide.”

The three exchanged nervous glances, with Lonnie being the one to step forward, “We won’t give you anything that could lead to you hurting…”

“You will give us enough to allow us to *survive* , my dear,” Angella’s tone was clipped, “We risked a lot. I think asking for an

understanding of our enemy isn't asking for a lot. Knowing what to do to avoid conflict is a start and asking you to chip in to ensure we all live is *not* an in extremis request, now, is it?"

"And if we say no?"

"Then hard tack and getting to sit in a stockade until we can ship you out will have to do," came the voice of Juliet from the crowd. The hardened security chief stepped into view and glared at the three, "What is your problem?"

Glimmer actually snorted and that got a glare from the security lead. The spunky former-bartender just planted her hands on her hips, "What? Like you've ever been a voice of calm rationality, Juliet."

That seemed to lighten the mood a little. Another voice cut through the air, "We do need help setting up some form of hydroponics. I'm sure I can keep them out of trouble there."

Angella glanced into the crowd and smiled, "Thank you Perfuma. That would be appreciated. We can discuss more when they have… had a chance to settle in. You will have to forgive me - I imagine it has been as trying for you as it has been for us. Easy to forget that."

Lonnie blinked and looked between Angella and Perfuma, then deflated a little and scratched at her arm, "Y…yeah. I'm sorry

ma'am. Just… feels like people have been asking us to compromise and do stuff and… it wears. Normal reaction. And for what it's worth, from all of us… we're sorry. And I owe Adora. Promised her we'd help. But it's hard, y'know?"

Angella nodded curtly, "It's a start. Juliet, did you see where Adora… ah, there she is."

The blonde walked up, trailed by Sea Hawk and a pair of other pilots. Angella frowned, while Perfuma and Juliet led the recently rescued away. Huntara crossed her arms and watched Adora carefully.

"Commander," Adora's voice was curt, masked by her visor. It came out clipped and slightly artificial, "I need to make use of the requisitioned gunships. For another retrieval."

"Already? You've just gotten back. This feels abrupt."

"The enemy fleet will be mobilising after this incident. We have a major concern - the arrival of the Governor. Our window to retrieve my ship is closing. If he decides to move it out of system that could be a benefit as it's likely they'll take a fair amount of the fleet too, given the main threats have been… pacified. But if that happens I have to follow."

That got a startled look from the Commander. Angella let out a breath while Glimmer groaned. The former bartender shook her

head, “I get it Adora. You need Swift Wind back, right?”

“Exactly. And I cannot let the Horde have any further access to him. Worst case, they break in and then begin to *really* investigate the planetoid. They aren’t stupid and, by all accounts, the lead technician in system is a genius. She will make a connection. And Catra will not give up. Not if there’s a chance to advance further. If I can retrieve the ship, then I can cause problems and keep the Horde off our backs.”

“And if you die?” Angella sounded exasperated, but as if she were trying to keep it under wraps.

“Then they will view a major threat as having been eliminated and will likely reduce their efforts to search. You will be viewed as a minor nuisance again and likely… tolerated. That will buy you time as well.”

Glimmer spluttered, “Adora!”

“It’s true. It’s a win either way. I have a preference, of course but… it’ll be worth it if I can buy you some time to cover your tracks for what you need to do.”

Silence fell on the group, with the pilots exchanging nervous glances. Angella just heaved a heavy sigh and shook her head, “Very well. I understand that Mermista and her crew have managed to distribute the IFF disruption coding to several probes

and it is likely propagating through the network. But Bow has also explained it may need refreshing, if their technical lead is as gifted as you say. That should allow you to approach via… specific routes."

Adora nodded, "I can emulate a patrol flight path. The new fleet will likely have the Horde on edge but also they won't notice a new patrol and will probably affiliate it with the *other* fleet."

"That's a broad assumption," mused Angella.

"Any other time, yes. But this short notice? We can use it against them."

"And you know where to go? How will you get past their defences with two gunships?"

"The gunships are just to get me where I need to go. I'll do the rest."

Glimmer studied Adora and shook her head slowly, "You're going to do something stupid, aren't you?"

Adora actually huffed, which sounded loud through her mask speakers, "Me? As *if* ."

Moments later, Glimmer and Angella watched as the pair of sleek, black gunships lifted off from the rock and peeled away into the nebula clouds. A puffing wheeze announced Bow's arrival and he groaned as she planted his hands on his hips to draw in a breath, "Did I miss her?"

"Yeah. She's going to do something dumb."

"Of course," he sighed and shook his head with a grin, "As expected."

"You seem awfully certain of that fact," Angella mused with a raised eyebrow.

Glimmer and Bow exchanged a glance, then looked at Angella, "Of course."

"Then why didn't you try to stop her, persuade her otherwise?"

Bow smiled sadly, "Why didn't you?"

That made the older woman pause. She chuckled, "I suppose so. Perhaps because I hope that, whatever she has planned, it might work. And… what would be the value of keeping her here?"

“Not worried about our cover being blown?” Glimmer’s smile was audible in her words.

“Hardly. That girl is… on a mission. And I am grateful she has chosen to work with us. Even with my folly. I suppose I have to… hope.”

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Adora does something reckless. And incredibly unsubtle.

Chapter Notes

And here... we.... go.

Yeah Adora isn't one for subtlety at times. Let's see how this goes for her!

Just a bridger to show you how absolutely batshit our girl is. Is it crazy? Yes. Is it entirely in line with how utterly irresponsible Adora can be in canon? Also yes. And is it an example of how She Ra does absolutely MAD stuff and somehow lives through it, of which I am indulging far too much in? OH HELL YES.

Hope you enjoyed ;)

“This plan is insane.”

Adora chuckled behind her mask as the gunship pilot grumbled over their local radio-net. She sat in the troop compartment of the ship. It wasn’t quite a transport, but had a cargo-cum-troop bay allowing it to act as a forward shock-troop transport as well as fire support. The crew all had their suits sealed for vacuum, due to Adora’s plan, which she’d briefed them on as they pulled out of the nebula cloud.

“It’ll work,” she reassured across the comm, which brought some disbelieving chuckles across in reply, “All you guys need to do is… fly casual.”

Her spirits were oddly high: the rescue of the two former Horde had lit something in her, something more than the sabotage missions and the attacks had ever done. She'd *saved* people and that felt *good* . Yes, her prior work had been about saving people, but it had been as an abstract result. She'd been a weapon, and her actions had kept people safe, but quite how she had always found to be a grey thing.

And right now, she felt she was saving something else: something for *her* . And it would mean, directly, saving other people. It gave her a clear sense of purpose, something she hadn't really had for a long time.

It had been basic: survive. That had been everything. Then it had been *keep people safe* , but that hadn't worked.

This recent turn, saving everyone on the station, then the Horde defectors? It felt like a light that had become a tiny flicker had roared to life. Something she hadn't felt since…

Since…

Since back at the academy.

When she'd been trying to keep Catra safe.

That memory caused a strange wash of emotions to ooze through her mind. Worry, mostly. The look she'd seen on Catra's face after they'd… kissed. It was one of despair, of guilt and anger.

But Adora knew what she was good at. She was excellent at it in fact. And it surprised her.

She was good at *saving* people. And she was going to save Catra even if she had to drag the woman kicking and screaming off the bridge of her burning flagship. She wasn't going to lose her to anything.

Not even herself.

Her thoughts were jerked aside as the pilot's voice came back again, "Transport convoy ahead. Just as you said."

Adora inhaled. The Horde was nothing if not predictable, following the routines Lonnie had given them - regular inbound logistics and in-system material movement. She spoke up, "Route?"

"Definitely charting a course to the ice planet. Seems they're moving from the fuel station. Are, uh… are you sure?"

"Any escorts?"

“A fighter contingent, plus some drones, but those look to be… dormant, still in their charge bays on the hulls.”

“Ok,” Adora brought up her wrist computer and typed in a command, “Here’s the ID codes. Bow and Casta scrambled together some, plus my own encryptions. That should pass inspection. Open the channel, let me do the talking. The fighters won’t care if we keep to a normal patrol pattern.”

“Just two gunships?”

“Let me do the talking… ok?”

She settled back and drew a slow breath, then waited. A moment later, the communicator crackled and a rasping, accented voice came through the comm, “ *This is Force master Krell of the Imperial Transport Ever-Hungers. Gunship TK421, adjust your trajectory - you are on an intercept vector.”*

Adora watched as her wrist-computer lit up - the comm link allowing her very basic access to the Transports systems. At this range it was *very* limited, only granting log access at most. She’d need a hardlink to get into the advanced systems. Her eyes and mind scanned the data at speed and she cleared her throat.

" Force Master Krell, this is Force Sergeant Carerro, of the Governor’s forward fleet, our IFF flags should make that clear. We are conducting a routine check of all transports as the Governor is

now in system. Slow your fleet to half ahead full and prepare for surface inspection and scanning. Inform your escort to maintain overwatch."

" *I was unaware of an inspection, Force Sergeant…"*

" It would rather defeat the *point* of announcing ahead of time, Force master. Now, slow, as I have several waypoints on my list and I do not wish to waste the Governor *or* the local command chain's time validating things and bringing you up on charges, under military code 1971, failure to comply with a lawful order."

"How dare…"

"We have rebel cells active in system. Failure to comply will result in me assigning your convoy group as hostile to the local net. You and your lackeys may shoot us down, but you will be kill on sight for *every* drone, turret and warship in this system. Now, permit me my scans and I can be on my way," She cut the comm, then switched channels, checking the data, "Ok, send them the identification codes over now. Move the gunships apart, slow approach, can you activate the missile tracking?"

"Uh… yes…" the pilot spoke slowly and Adora heard worried murmurs from across their local net as the gunners readied themselves. She let a slow breath escape her lips and counted to ten. The pilot spoke up, "They're hailing us again, Adora."

She smirked and switched channels, " *Force Sergeant, my apologies. We were aware the rebels had somehow seized military equipment and… well, your codes checked out. Our weapons are powered down, if you can please make your scans and… I would be most appreciative if you did not raise this with the command chain. I am simply following protocol."*

"Your diligence in the face of challenge is to be applauded, Force master. I completely understand and we will be as swift as we can. I will note your *exemplary* co-operation and focus on the rules to the Governor. Please transfer a summary of your manifest to our vessel, so we may corroborate."

"Of course. Transferring now, Ever-Hungers out."

Adora blew out a breath then stood. She felt the gunship lurch as they adjusted course and her radio crackled again, "Moving in, Adora. As per your flight plan."

"Remember, two passes. First along either side of the convoy, then loop back *above and below* . Keep the scanners running. Match speed, force each vessel when running the above and below sweep, keep it slower as you do the initial run, as you're flying in the *opposite* direction so will just go too fast and they'll think you aren't properly scanning them."

"Not my first time…"

Adora shook her head and allowed herself a thin smile. She felt the gunship slow its initial run and checked her computer - the

manifest matched so far. Her stomach went weightless for a brief moment as the gunship turned and she reached over, letting the access hatch slide open. There was the briefest hiss as what little atmosphere remained whooshed out. The silent void met her view and she watched the convoy as it curved in her view as the gunship pivoted the line up. Their gunship was the one *below* the half-dozen transport freighters, out of view of the bridges and most portholes. There were basic sensors and cameras, but she wasn't worried; they'd be watching the gunships, yes, but she wouldn't register.

The gunship rolled as the pilot manoeuvred it closer and she switched comms, listening in case the transports queried the move. The gunship closed to within fifty metres of the ships, then angled and accelerated a little. Adora sprung out of the door as it did so, allowing herself to cannonball up and towards the transport, but at a shallow angle. If she got this wrong, she'd drift past its bow and have to be retrieved… and getting a second run wasn't likely. Too sharp and she'd impact the hull *hard* . And that could mean a suit rupture or worse.

She adjusted as she flew closer, keeping her suit as passive as she could. Slowly, the Transport came closer until she was able to twist in space and activate her boots.

She came to a jarring halt as the magnets in the boots dragged her close and forced her to impact, her momentum almost resulting in a face-plant. She braced her arms and caught her self, wincing at the stretch in her legs - zero g landings like this were always tricky, but her conditioning made it a lot easier. With a slow breath, she consulted her wrist computer and watched as the gunships peeled away, then activated her comm, "Inspection

complete, green across the board, Force master. Carry on and glory to the Empire.”

“Glory to the empire. Good day, out.”

She chuckled at the surly attitude - hardly unexpected. Freighter masters were barely above grunts in the wider hierarchy. Haulers with a modicum of rank, imperial freighter captains tended to lord it over the civilian lot, having more preferable treatments and better conditions, as well as guaranteed work. That brought a certain level of *arrogance.* And also a certain level of incompetence that could be leveraged.

Phase one was done. Now for phase two.

She made her slow way along the belly of the transport. To call it a transport was the most base of descriptions - these ships were basically scaffolding with a crew compartment and engines strapped to them. Interlocking cargo pods were clamped to the central frame, their oblong shapes giving the ship a boxy look. The placement of the containers meant there was a slim gap between the upper and lower set of containers, allowing access to the scaffolding at the centre, where a maintenance tunnel ran from the crewed aft of the vessel. This allowed the crew to check the containers and enter them if need be. Not all containers had the feature, of course (No need to access a fuel container, for example) but there were status readouts and various modular elements.

Of course, to someone with a suit of nasty tricks in their suit, it meant Adora could access the containers as well, but from *outside* the tunnel - there'd be an airlock here, in case of an emergency need to go external, but few crews would to that - usually waiting until they docked to flag the issue.

Adora didn't want to get *into* the ship though - too much risk of discovery. And that would mean a fight, the chance a warning could get out and things would *escalate* . And then she would be, as Glimmer was known to say, *shit out of luck* .

Instead, she squeezed in between the dividing containers and found the docking collar for one of the massive cargo-carriers. There were additional clamps all along, keeping it secured. Without any containers, the ship would look like a child's drawing of a branch - a bulky base, with a single spine and multiple spindles spearing off of it: more like scaffolding, than a ship.

It was the work of a moment to secure herself near the central docking point and, with a palm pressed against the out hull of the access-tunnel, Adora accessed the local computer of the container. A brief manifest popped up - mostly construction material, strangely - steel rebar, cables and the like. Not for a ship, though. Rather it was for a structure.

It looked like the Horde were planning to entrench on the planet this vessel was heading to, or at the very least begin construction of a Star-Fort to act as a bulwark. Captured stations were fine, Adora knew, but longer term you needed purpose built facilities to act as central hubs or way-stations; or even to just hold key stellar-points.

Stick a floating station covered in weaponry at a key orbital point or lagrange jump point around a planet and you made life a lot harder for anyone trying to land. Not *impossible* , but it'd mean they would need to land on-planet far away from a key objective and that would give you superiority.

It also would then free up your fleet to patrol, rather than having to hold mobile assets in reserve or defence. The Horde tended to keep their fleets *active* .

The frontier ones, at least. She knew how sedentary the Imperial Guard were around the capital. Hardly any of those had moved in decades, all gilded vessels and white armour, with fat captains, draped in gilt and stolen valour.

Adora huffed and risked checking the wider manifest. More of the same. She checked to see if there was a more suitable container, but this one would suffice. She found one of the hoses that connected the vessel to the container itself and, after having unhooked the warning system, connected it to her suit via a quick jury-rig and judicious use of her knife blade. A moment later she was hooked into the system's atmospherics, meaning her limited oxygen supply was now no longer a risk. She didn't exactly care about degradation inside the container - likely as not, it hadn't even been properly activated, given there was no cargo that would need an atmosphere inside at any rate.

The convoy sped up as the gunships peeled away - she'd told the pilots to conduct a mock patrol until they were beyond sensor range, then to return to the resistance base. She didn't need an

evac - and, frankly, even if she did, two gunships weren't likely to cut it. This was a one way trip if she got this wrong.

Which, given how she was going about it, was *very* likely. She chuckled to herself at that. If she'd told Glimmer, the small woman would have likely broken one of her bar's bottles over her head, what few they'd salvaged. Bow would've started hyperventilating.

Adora settled down and, after ensuring she was tethered to the vessel, let her mind slip into a more meditative state. It was one she always found hard, as her brain tended to overthink at the best of times. But it had been drilled into her. It let her body slow, almost to a hibernation point.

And yet her mind still raced, visions of a certain feline in her mind's eye. Before it had always been a desperate hope, a flimsy shield against the other memories. But now it felt more real. Visceral. Her conflicted feelings were pretty laser focused now. She stared into nothingness as around the convoy the inky void passed, uncaring of the tiny motes that drifted within it.

After what seemed an eternity Adora jolted into *proper* consciousness. The ship rocked as it slowed and Adora checked her wrist computer. It showed it had been a good couple of hours. She'd actually fallen into a pretty deep contemplation and took a shuddering breath as her gaze flicked to regard the vista beyond the thin line she could make out between the gap in the containers.

She could make out the edge of the planet - a white curve, indicating the disc of the world below. It alone would have been breath-taking but that wasn't what made her breath hitch.

It was the shockingly large *fleet* that hung in the void around a ramshackle spoke of a station - the thing was clearly a rudimentary orbital platform, likely left behind and now repurposed by Catra and her forces. It was acting as a temporary shuttle station and cargo storage. That alone would have been noteworthy, but the massive Command Carrier behind it, flanked by its attendant frigates and destroyers made her stomach clench.

Veritable *swarms* of drones and fighters screeched about, briefly blotting out the stars as they wheeled. Adora remembered an old story, back when she and Catra had scrounged for scraps before their conscription into the academy. A tale of dark creatures that lived in stony old buildings, called *castles* ; the winged creatures that lived in caves that blotted out the moon as they flocked at sunset, a harbinger of terror and fear.

Her jaw clenched, "Fear *me* ," she hissed to herself, "I'll break all your toys, whoever you are."

Hordak, Lonnie had mentioned. Another corrupt servant of the Empire. Another thing between her and peace. She'd get through him.

Adora returned her gaze to her wrist computer and accessed the vessel's flight plan. It seemed that the cargo was to be detached

and stored at the orbital, then moved to the planet via grav-loaders. She smirked.

That wouldn't do at all. Far too much time.

A few taps brought up a red-wireframe on her screen - a hastily constructed and rudimentary map of the position of the freighters as they lined up to unhook their containers for the waiting cargo shuttles. The squat hauler shuttles looked like more basic versions of swift wind: not legs, just a set of boosters and manipulator arms to move the containers onto cradles around the orbital.

Adora couldn't let *her* container be anchored. She'd have to find a way down to the planet then, and that increased the risk of discovery. Any vessel flying down from orbit was going to be checked with a lot more rigour, especially with a Command Carrier *right* there. No, she needed a distraction and an express elevator.

Which was what she'd planned for anyway. Just this was now much more important.

She unhooked herself from the container and half floated, half pulled herself along the rows back towards the vessel itself. She'd need direct access to its systems for this. And timing would be crucial.

Adora wasn't a techie, not by *any* stretch. She knew how Swiftwind worked and how some of the *freaky* tech worked, but that wasn't entirely *her* - it was the implanted knowledge and ingrained muscle memory given by her suit and nanites. But she'd

picked up enough to know how to break things without making it look like sabotage.

It wasn't hard to find an access port, just next to where the main trunk of the ship met the housing and engine frame. That gave her much greater access to the ship's systems. Her suit helped a *lot* , but she was able to set up a timer in the electrical system that would work to her advantage. She had fifteen minutes before the vessels were aligned. Seven of those she spent priming the ship's thrusters and main engine. Two she spent rigging the release clamp signal.

Three she spent crawling back to her original container and securing herself against it.

She saw the other freighters being lined up, and haulers already unhooking and moving the containers of the freighters to the fore. She held her breath and checker wrist computer and then closed her eyes as she counted down. One of the haulers turned, moving sluggishly through the void towards *her* freighter, clearly prepping to begin detachment.

The ship lurched as its thrusters fired, along with its main engine as the surprised helmsman overcompensated and likely charged the engine on reflex. There was the sickening, albeit dulled, sound of screeching metal, only really detectable as it vibrated into Adora's suit, as the freighter scraped the rear underside of the freighter in front of it.

Then the first container at the fore ejected in a spray of burst atmosphere cables - oxygen cyrstalised in the void as the container arced, slowly away. It clipped a hauler that spun away, trailing sparks. Another container burst from below, then another, before suddenly all the top-most containers ejected, cartwheeling away. Another burst of the thrusters sent the freighter down, dangerously close to the planet's gravitational pull. Adora felt it shudder as the helmsman was clearly putting his effort into keeping the ship stable. Above, with the containers now jettisoned, Adora could see the local logistics fleet in a flurry - haulers zipping off to catch or slow the spinning containers, the other freighters flashing warning lights as they broke formation, half unloaded containers jostling and crashing, spilling more away from their secure struts. It wasn't *complete* chaos, but enough.

She could see a pair of haulers and shuttles bearing down towards the crew compartment, aiming to either rescue the crew or stabilise the ship.

Another thruster surge pointed the vessel down further and Adora could see warning lights flare. A hauler attached to the aft of the freighter and she could imagine it blasting a t full burn.

Time to help out. She grinned and triggered then held on as the last triggers engaged and the final few containers ejected out - this time she imagined it was the crew blasting them free to save the vessel. Cargo could be recovered, a ship tended to carry a severe penalty for the Captains if they failed to do what they could.

Like a cork from a bottle, the freighter lurched and pivoted, its struts creaking under the strain as it sprang back to level. The

shuttles and other haulers clamped on dragging it back into upper orbit, while the remaining three cargo containers spiralled away into the atmosphere. Adora could see the glow from the other two as they punched into the thin, cold air.

This was going to be the painful part.

She crawled up the now-clear hatch, as gravity began to take hold. Thin whistling wind was just audible, but no air pressure at that point. Adora overrode the entrance lock, before she managed to crawl inside. The sudden shit threatened to push her up into the "ceiling". She was glad the cargo inside was secure, but she knew *that* would be temporary.

There was a lurch as the container hit the atmosphere and began to tumble. Auto-thrusters kicked in as it tried to stabilise. These things weren't just boxes: they were designed to be *guided* down after all, but without a pair of haulers or a freight shuttle, the thing was in a barely guided free fall. Adora gritted her teeth, barely able to make out her own HUD on her eyes, let alone her wrist computer, as the containers began to spin. Her muscles strained as centrifugal forces began to drag her away from the hatch. She had to stay *inside* for the moment, as the tell-tale glow of re-entry showed that the heat *outside* was getting pretty close to fatal. Again, the containers were shielded for that, but anything on the surface was going to be fried by air friction.

There was another jolt and the container lurched, the floor becoming the ceiling and vice versa. Adora let out a pained grunt as she was slammed against a stack of piled girders. There wasn't much room, just this alcove in the centre of the container, with crates and girders boxing it in.

The thrusters fired again as the container's basic AI tried to make sense of things. It normally would be hooked into a flight system, so right now it was doing its darndest. But that wasn't going to be enough. Adora could feel the thing rattling as it tumbled. There was the shriek of metal and a crack split across one side of the hold. Then another. Wind squealed in and the crates rattled. A second past and Adora blinked, before a whole wall of the container tore away, taking girders and crates with it. Wind and ice whipped in, and Adora scrambled away and sought the "top" of the container. She managed to make it, narrowly avoiding a whole pallet of metal rods and grides as they spun out of the hole and into the storm beyond. A moment later and the wind was all there was, the visibility clear as the crate tumbled through a cloud. Adora clung on and crawled, wind deafeningly loud around her as the container plummeted. She could see the tops of *massive* mountains, along with a vast, white expanse, dotted with grey-black ridges and rocks. Far in the distance was the glitter of landight lights. She could see some moving, clearly on an intercept course: likely a retrieval team already en route.

She took this in in a millisecond, before her attention was drawn back to the plummet.

"Not… the… best…. Idea…" she ground out as, with a rattling howl, more metal tore free. Around her, the container practically disintegrated as the thrusters, meant to stabilise the thing, instead tore it apart as the integrity failed. The computer didn't know, it was trying to balance a load that wasn't there anymore.

With a curse Adora let go and pushed off the container, activating the weak jet pack in her suit. It arrested her fall enough to let her

clear the main debris cloud as it fell. She spun in the air, still tumbling, looking around for what she needed, growling in satisfaction as she did. A large sheet of the container spun away, slowing as it descended, but still falling fast. Her boost activated and she dove towards it, impacting the fragment of the container with a grunt. It spun and she slid along it, but managed to get her fingers into what had once been a former storage locker, now partly torn away.

She crawled along the fragment and managed to angle it, using her magnetised boots and booster until it was level. It wobbled and she angled it down, her feet braced. The wind whipped as she saw the ground looming up ever closer, closer. Well, not the ground - a mountain-side. The direct fall became a steep glide as she trident to arrest some momentum. Snow and rock loomed in the dim light as Adora pivoted the metal. It caught the briefest updraft, like a leaf on the wind and, by mere millimetres, skipped the tip of a ridge, before she was once more into a near controlled free-fall. She braced, then jumped as the fragment hit the snowy side of the mountain, what was little more than a cliff. She landed and grunted in pain as her knees nearly buckled.

Ahead she could see metal and scrap slamming into the rock and snow, sending up crates of ice and splinters of stone.

The sheet of steel was still going horrifically fast. She knew she would be little more than a thin streak if they hit anything in their way. Adora inhaled, turned and activated her boosters, noting how low they were running. Her eyes widened in frustrated horror as she saw what was behind her, however: their impact had caused a bit of a problem - a full scale wall of snow tumbled behind her, chasing her down the mountain.

With a curse Adora cut the booster, spun and took it all in: the way the cliff sprang back *up* into a jagged wall of rocks; the gulleys, the snow behind her.

She jumped, off to the side, firing her meagre boosters as she went, her suit still sealed. She hit the snow and tumbled, her momentum arrested enough, just enough. She continued to roll and tumble, while her former ride smashed into the rocky formation and split, before it cartwheeled up and over into the beyond, wrecked (even more so). Adora managed to boost over it as well, as her booster beeped it was almost done. As she arced over the spiky rocks, all she could see below her was a void of blackness: a crevasse between two parts of the mountain.

Then nothing but white as the avalanche crashed over the small ridge and filled her vision. Adora dropped into the white wave and vanished.

The rumble of snow faded away to echoes, marred only by the remaining faint thumps as small pieces of debris thudded into the ground. High above a pair of shuttles blasted across the snowy tundra and rockscape, search-lamps glowing as they mapped the debris field, before they turned and roared back towards the distant lights of the ice-base.

Silence settled on the mountainside as the stars twinkled above.

A fist punched out through the snow. The hand flexed and grabbed on, clawing at the powder, as Adora hauled herself from her icy would-be-tomb. Her mask retracted and she drew in a ragged, cold breath, then lolled back, still half submerged in the compacted snow. Around her suit it had begin to melt as her survival systems extricated her. She spat a glob of blood onto the snow and winced, rolling a shoulder. With effort, she dragged herself free and managed to hobble towards a rock-shelf on the slope. With a twisted move and a swing, followed by a hiss, she popped her shoulder back into place, then rotated it as the nanites repaired things.

Her gaze settled on the lights, a good few miles away. She looked back up at the stars and nodded to herself, "Not bad, Adora. Not bad. We got this. Just remember to NEVER tell Glimmer. Or Bow. Or Huntara. Or Angella. Or Catra."

She wobbled and shook her head, giggling maniacally at that last one, slightly giddy - she could imagine the feline being exasperated on a whole OTHER level, even with them being technically enemies. Especially given all the... weirdness recently. Adora blew out a breath. She checked her suit and ensured it was refilling its oxygen tanks, then refastened her visor and began to trudge down the slope. She glared straight ahead.

"I'm coming for you, Swifty. I'm coming."

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

Reap. The. Whirlwind.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Scorpia sighed as she toyed with the data pad in her claws. It was frozen on the image of a blonde, frizzy-haired woman with freckles and a dimpled smile. For some reason, Scorpia hadn't been able to move on from the little recording she'd found in that hydroponics bay, many many days before. It nagged at her, like a splinter, an intrusive thought. The sheer earnest *hope* in the woman's voice, the trust.

It called to something in Scorpia. A distant memory of kind people and gentle smiles.

Before the seriousness, the austerity of the Empire.

Around her, in the base command centre on the dreary ice world, comms officers and troopers scuttled, co-ordinating after the latest debacle. Catra had reached out, a terse communique. She had clearly been frustrated, initially fearing a rebel assault of some sort; but scans had indicated that the freighter had simply misaligned and driven itself out of orbit, likely due to some engine or navigational failure.

Scorpia had *no* desire to be the Force Master of *that* vessel. Especially with the Sector Governor in person visiting; Catra would likely be forced to do something really unpleasant and Scorpia knew she was under a *lot* of pressure. Their stunt with the prisoners had, hopefully, paid off, but it felt like something had changed. She'd practically flashed here, after Catra had ordered her back on site.

Entrapta was being more squirrely than normal, practically locked in the auxiliary hangar bay with her new pet project. The captured shuttle was nearly forgotten, just sitting surrounded by various sensors and instruments. Right now, several laser cutters were pulsing against the shield, slowly melting it away. It was creepy to watch, like they were carving away at a living thing. It unsettled Scorpia so much, she avoided the hangar, despite only having been at the base for little more than a couple of days. And now the Governor and Catra were in orbit, and a freighter had crashed and *everyone* was on edge and Scorpia was feeling exceedingly off kilter.

She tapped the data pad and it shut off. The Commander turned her attention to the room at large, focusing on the nearest communications officer. Her command desk was to the rear of the room, with the rest of the desks set up in rows facing a large screen at the end that displayed myriad smaller views of data. This hub was air traffic control, base monitoring and Operations all in one.

"Report on the recovery."

The officer turned and nodded, their face haggard. The trooper was some sort of squid-kin, their uniform adapted to

accommodate water, which made them look bulkier than the others. The soldier warbled and their translator kicked in, “Ma’am, debris is scattered across the southern mountain range. Looks like the majority of the carbon was construction material, base metals. Two shuttles have managed to recover seven tonnes of steel but it appears to have been warped in re-entry.”

“Entrapta will make use of it, somehow,” huffed the Commander, “Anything to report on the salvage - nothing suspicious?”

The officer frowned and shook their head, “No ma’am, reports from orbit say that the crew have been taken into custody. Some issues with their logs, it would appear they tried to wipe them, but the Force Master is claiming he didn’t. Either way, the security detail on board the Governor’s vessel has them in custody, so reports are scarce.”

Scorpia shook her head and snorted, “Oh well, likely a doozy of an error. Some poor sap forgot their maintenance and now got their whole crew penal colony sentences for jeopardising a critical operation.”

She paused as another officer began speaking, “Maintenance to access hatch 15. Door seems to have jammed half open. We’ve sealed an interior door to preserve thermal integrity.”

“What’s happening?” The squid-kin returned to their station as Scorpia frowned at this new source of interest - anything to stave off the boredom of desk duty.

The officer turned, “Routine beacon patrol just clocked back in, but the idiots didn’t seal the door, ma’am. It triggered open and jammed.”

“Wildlife triggering it?” Scorpia cocked her head, “Anything suspicious?” she almost sounded hopeful. Her anxiety was acting up if anything. The officer smiled ruefully.

“No ma’am. Only things on this rock are ice worms and they’re in the temperate belt. No sightings of them there, though, let alone up here. I’ve got a detail to check. And nothing on the sensor logs to show entry. Had a whole team down there anyway so they’d have reported *something* the size of an ice worm!”

Scorpio sighed and nodded, “Carry on. I’m going to the canteen. Lieutenant, you have the room.”

One of the officers standing near to her desk saluted and slid into her vacant seat as Scorpia stood and strode out, her data pad tucked against her side. The corridors weren’t packed - most troopers were on station or in their racks catching some rest between shifts - and the canteen was relatively quiet. Scorpia hummed to herself as she carefully retrieved the scalding coffee from the dispenser unit and turned to head back to the command centre.

As she stepped into the corridor she stopped short, almost running into a soldier. The trooper had their full battle dress on,

with a helmet visor down. Scorpia blinked in surprise and grinned, “Expecting trouble, trooper?”

The soldier’s visor gazed blankly back at her, before the voice returned, slightly muffled, “Uh, no ma’am, sorry ma’am, something wrong ma’am?”

Scorpia squinted, “No need to be all geared up, soldier! We aren’t under attack.”

“Um, regulations state that, in case of emergency, all troops are to be equipped until the emergency is cleared.”

The Commander frowned and shook her head, “That was a freighter crash, not an incursion, we’ve reduced the alert status.”

“Didn’t want to leave my helmet just lying around, ma’am…”

Scorpia sighed and shook her head, “Are you new here trooper?”

“Just transferred in, ma’am.”

Something niggled at the Commander, but the soldier was so rigid at attention, she took pity on them, “What’s your name, super-trooper?”

“G…Grey, ma’am.”

“Well Trooper Grey, we run a tight ship, but you need the right kit for the right situation. Where’s your detail?”

“Just heading to my duty station in the hangar ma’am.”

“All right, carry on.”

She shook her head as the trooper threw up a hasty salute and scurried away. However, as she stepped forward, her boot slipped on something and she had to steady herself, the action sending her mug spraying its boiling contents over the wall, “Shoot, gosh, darn, whooops!” Scorpia hissed as she righted herself.

She shook her head and glanced down, then did a double take. Patches of snow and ice covered the metal floor, leaving a boot trail. Fascinated, confused, Scorpia traced the trail back up the corridor, to one of the locker rooms, where she could hear panicked cursing. She peered around the hatch to see a young woman scrambling around her bunk, with only dress pants and an undershirt. The woman looked to be tearing her locker apart, “Where the hell is it, where? Who busts open a locker?”

“Problem, trooper?”

The soldier spun around, "Oh! Uh Commander. I… uh, I think I'm… I'm being pranked. I mean, not that anyone here would disobey regulations but… but…"

The woman looked terrified, so Scorpia held up her pincers in a placating gesture, "Hey, hey now, no need to worry. Now, calm down, deep breaths, in and out and let's have a chit chat about what's going on. I'm sure it's not that serious…"

"My armour ma'am… I… I know it's a chargeable offence to mislay issued equipment but I swear it was secured in the locker, I swear. Code locked, everything. I have the logs to say i checked it in after my patrol, all clean so it wasn't in there getting rank, I didn't give it the quarter master I swear it…"

Scorpia frowned, then cocked her head as the soldier babbled on. A few things slowly clicked into place as she glanced down at the floor and saw a rapidly drying trail of melted ice and snow. Her head turned inexorably towards the door and an eyebrow raised as her mind went click-click-click. Her eyes widened and she sprinted for the comm panel near the door, slamming the *talk* button, "Commander Scorpia to Command Centre - lock down the hangar, I say again, lock down the hangar, security to stations, arm up! Base to *red alert* . Secure Chief Engineer Entrapta, seal all exits and *lock down the hangar!"*

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The sudden dimming of the lights to red and the slow warble of alarm caused Adora to let out a heavy sigh. It had been going really well - she'd managed to trek all the way to the base,

shadowed a barely attentive patrol and even been able to get in close enough to remote disable the door lock *and* trigger it open again, although the door wasn't a smart lock, so it'd required her fusing a few wires externally as well. She'd managed to sneak in and get all the way to a locker to get the disguise, but she'd not been as careful as she'd imagined. Running into the Catra's XO had been the *worst* luck and it was likely the, frankly, huge woman had triggered the alarm.

Catra didn't tolerate idiots; Adora found herself quietly impressed, if indeed it had been the woman. It could've been the soldier whose armour she'd pilfered, but honestly a Horde trooper wouldn't trigger a lock down over a missing set of gear - that'd be far too risky that they'd get blamed.

Right now she'd just managed to slip into the hangar bay. And not too soon. As soon as she did, the access doors had clanged shut and the lighting had changed. All over the room, technicians and troopers ran too and fro, clearly panicked.

But panic we can use , she thought to herself. Her gaze took the room in, before her sights settled on something familiar. And her heart lurched.

Swift Wind stood on a landing pad, surrounded by machines of all types, shapes and configurations. The shielded bubble around the mech rippled as a pair of plasma torches pulsed against it, clearly trying to overwhelm the vessel. And it was working. Static, the generator inside could hold out against a *lot* . But it had limits. Clearly they hadn't wanted to risk damaging her ship, at least initially - that no longer seemed the case.

She made her way around the edge of the hangar, moving with sharp movements, mirroring the other confused soldiers around the bay. As she did, she analysed her options. Getting close to Swift Wind could cause the ship to drop the shield… and that would mean the cutters would absolutely shred her ship.

But waiting meant an increased chance of detection and the higher risk of a fight.

So, she needed to disable the machinery, secure her ship, then work out how to get out of a locked down, underground hangar.

Adora grimaced under her helmet, then froze as she realised that one of the techs was waving at her. She paused, then slowly moved towards them. The tech looked agitated, their goggles on their forehead. On closer inspection, she realised it was a young man, mostly human, with blue scales up his neck. He looked pensive, glancing about nervously, "Hey, HEY! What's going on? We just got told there's an intruder and the place is on lockdown?"

Adora cocked her head and looked around. She offered a shrug, "No idea. I was just told to report here to support the… whatever is going on there…" she waved at Swift Wind, managing to keep her cool, "Next thing I know it's all flashing lights and alarms. I wasn't even issued a weapon!"

The tech snorted, “Tell me about it. Quartermaster keeps it all on lockdown, bet she’s regretting that now. Mind you,” he glanced over at a set of sealed blast doors, “Whoever is in here is going to have a hard time once the walkers are out, y’know?”

“Walkers? I just got shipped in, came with the Governor’s advanced guard… they don’t tell us *anything* . Is it…” Adora leaned closer, “Weapons?”

The tech grinned, “Oh yeah. Entrapta’s had me working on a few. Not her baby. Entrapta’s the chief if you didn’t know. And, well…”

“Hey! You two! Enough chatter, get in position. Trooper, where the *hell* is your rifle?”

Adora looked over to where a Force Sergeant, helmetless, was ordering his troops into position behind barricades. Adora shrugged again, “Sorry Force Sergeant, I just got told to report in. Was told to get here asap, then the alarm went off.”

“Who’s Company are you from?”

“New transfer, Governor’s fleet, Force Sergeant. Left my kit on the rack and the Commander told me to double time it down here, didn’t know where I wa…”

“Alright, enough of the backstory, rookie. Fenri, chuck the newbie your shock stick. It’ll have to do. If whatever is in the base gets past us, you best save the day, rookie.”

One of the troopers unhooked the stun-stick from their belt and tossed it to Adora. She fumbled it, then clutched it tight, which drew a few laughs from the other troopers. The Force Sergeant had them in a battle line, hunkering down behind several crates and racks of building supplies. They were mid way between the door Adora had come through and Swift Wind. Adora stepped carefully up, behind the line as the troopers focused on the door.

The alarms cut out suddenly, leaving strobing red lights to swirl in the silence. There was a crackle as the tannoy came to life and Scorpia’s voice blared out, *“All stations, be advised. The intruder is wearing Imperial Armour, Trooper designation. All troopers are to remove their helmets and present themselves for roll call for their immediate squad-leads. While each trooper does this, maintain vigilance and engage IMMEDIATELY to disable the intruder…”*

Adora watched as the Froze Sergeant froze and began to slowly turn her way.

She didn’t wait. The shock stick struck the base of the man’s spine and he spasmed as she discharged the weapon. His body locked up and he tumbled to the floor. The technician squealed in shock, but Adora was already moving. The soldiers were shocked, some not having noticed, still listening to the tannoy as Scorpia repeated her orders. Adora was on the nearest soldier and jabbed him with the shock stick, before she flicked it away to slam into the visor of another soldier. She spun like a dancer, and kicked up the stunned soldier’s rifle, aimed and fired once. The blast of

plasma seared into another trooper's leg. She went down with a cry. Adora turned again and another round hit the weapon of a fourth soldier. The weapon melted and flared, the magazine discharging in a cloud of heated vapour which sent the trooper down, shrieking in shock as they flailed at their scorched uniform.

Adora whirled and threw her rifle into the face of a fifth trooper who was turning. A plasma blast sizzled past Adora's shoulder as she followed her throw and jogged *over* the stunned soldier, planting a foot against his chest and walking *up* him to vault over him. She planted her knees into the chest of the soldier beyond him and drove the man to the ground, before she rolled off him, the man's rifle now in her hands, before she spun and fired a few bursts off, driving the soldiers at the other end of the barricade off, sending them scurrying for cover.

The tech was sprinting for the main hangar door in a blind panic, but Adora ignored him and fired up at the spotlights above, shattering a few. Part of the hangar was plunged into gloom, but not darkness.

More bolts of plasma seared by as several soldiers rallied from across the hangar's expanse.

"Weapons fire detected in the hangar bay. All security redeploy to the hangar. Secure the asset. Reinforcements inbound from orbit."

Adora cursed - stealth mission failed. Now it was a firefight.

She took stock, then went to one knee and fired a burst at the support strut that held one of the plasma cutters that was currently tormenting *her* ship. The cutter wobbled and she fired again, ducking as more bolts flashed her way. The troopers were rallying fast.

A third burst slagged the strut and the machine's own vibrations caused it to wobble. Adora ducked again and rolled into cover behind a set of building material. She swore as metal burst as the super heated plasma melted through above and around her.

With a crash, the plasma cutter toppled over, rolling ever so slightly. The beam flashed up and across, leaving a glowing red and gold line of scorched metal up the hangar wall and to one of the gantries above. With a shriek of metal and the hiss of melting slag, the gantry groaned and snapped free, half of it swinging down, scattering several troopers as they split to avoid the debris.

Adora ducked out and fired blindly, which made the soldiers rethink their attempt to advance. Above, the lance of plasma continued to burn a hole in the overhead roof, melting wiring, steel and plating.

The hiss of massive locks disengaging caused Adora to glance at the sealed doors along the hangar edge - one was sliding open, revealing a dimly lit interior within. She frowned as a pair of what looked like *mechs* emerged. She swore - these looked to be cargo mechs, nothing like her Swift Wind - these were dock-side cargo loaders. But they looked souped up, hauling large weapons in their long arms. Their frames also seemed to be covered in a sickly green and red wiring. Adora blinked in shock.

They *couldn't* have? Surely?

With a curse she scrambled away as one of the mechs turned her way, the pilot in its hooded cockpit spotting her easily. It raised its weapon and fired, the heavy round obliterating the cover where she had been. The things seemed to be carrying anti-material weaponry - slug throwers designed to knockout *armour* . From behind the mechs surged something else - one of the Horde squid droids. The tentacled *thing* flowed into the room and made a beeline for Adora. She sprinted and vaulted, launching herself towards the collapsed gantry. She slammed into the metal and scrambled up, just as tendrils swiped at where she *had* been. The squid gripped the trailing gantry and began to climb after Adora.

She gripped a trailing cable with one arm and pushed away, swinging off from the gantry, suspended a good thirty feet above the hangar floor. As she swung, she aimed her rifle and fired a burst. The squid drone caught the blast in an optic and spun away with a robotic squeal. A moment later and part of the gantry splintered away as the mechs on the ground opened fire, their slow blasts eating away at her escape route. Adora swung back, and she began to shimmy up the wire rapidly, before she was level with the intact part of the gantry itself. She vaulted onto it and began to spring along, firing blindly below as blaster shots flew up and around her.

She saw the hanagar entry open and more troops began to spill in - she was nearly out of time.

She zeroed in on the plasma cutters again - the second one was still pummelling Swift Wind's shields. Taking a risk, she dove forward to slide along the narrow gang-way and fired at the generator powering the device. Her bolts found their mark, melting into the fuel cells on the device. There was the loud whine and hiss of fuel overloading and Adora curled into a ball.

There was a sudden silence as air was sucked in, followed by a cacophonous blast that sent the gantry swinging. There was the snap-snap-snap of moorings failing and the whole thing lurched and dropped a little as the cables began to fail. All around were the groans and shouts of stunned and shocked troopers.Secondary explosions echoed as spare fuel cells detonated - the hangar floor was strewn with burning fuel and unconscious and wounded soldiers. The newly arrived detail were hauling troopers out of the hangar and trying to spot Adora in the chaos.

She groaned and pushed off the gantry, looking for a safe way down. The choice was taken away as the squid-drone slammed into the gantry and tore it free. Adora shouted and fell away. She managed to grab another cable, but it broke free from the ceiling and she barely arrested her fall before she hit the deck, hard. The wind was knocked out of her but the nanites kicked in, sealing the cracks in her bones. Wincing she pushed to her feet and realised her rifle was gone. A couple of discarded shock sticks lay nearby, as well as a busted weapon and a few dazed and injured soldiers. One groaned and eyed her, raising a pistol in a shaky hand. She snapped out a kick that sent the weapon flying before she plucked the shock sticks for the floor. She drove one into the soldier's shoulder which promptly made the trooper spasm then fall limp.

A shock stick wasn’t going to be good enough. With the flames all around and the smoke obscuring things, Adora had a few scant seconds. She hauled up part of the gantry railing -a long hollow pipe - and jammed a shock stick into either end, their business ends sparking. She twirled her make-shift weapon, then turned to where Swift Wind stood.

A squad of troopers had circled the fiery debris field and were now trying to form a line. Among them, Adora spotted Scorpia, barking orders.

The woman led from the front at least.

Well, one way to get your enemy to rout - cut the head off. With a growl, Adora sprinted through the flames and up a stack of broken debris, vaulting over it. Her muscles screamed as her augmentations powered more energy into them. The soldiers turned to stare at her, agog as she flew from the flames. A few raised weapons and fired, but Adora was suddenly among them.

She spun and struck, using the pole as a bludgeon to send troops to the ground. She twirled, spun the pole-arm and drove the electrical prods into her targets. One, then another, they went down. Another she dropped with a leg sweep, while she swept the pole-arm with one hand, cracking the leg of another soldier. She jammed the prod into one downed trooper, which caused the weapon to bounce up and she directed the arc to flip it and drive it into another downed soldier.

Adora twirled the weapon and darted back, narrowly missing a jab from a barbed tail. Scorpia stood, half crouched in a battle stance. Her claws snapped nervously. Adora smirked under her helmet, "Step aside, Commander. No one else needs to get hurt today."

"No one had to anyway. You just had to go away. I know she wanted you.. .away." Scorpia's voice was low and stern.

"And no one else would get hurt? How many families lost loved ones already? All the Empire *does* is hurt. How many people do you get to harm before it's *acceptable* for people to fight back? You don't get to punch down then complain when people punch back."

Scorpia huffed and shook her head, "That's… not for us to decide. We can only do our best."

"Then I'd hate to see your worst," With that Adora lunged. Scorpio brought her claw up and caught the overhead swing. She smirked at Adora, then grunted as Adora planted a boot into her stomach and kicked her back. The Praetorian yanked the weapon free, spun, then drove it like a spear towards Scorpia in a reverse thrust. The taller woman lurched to one side to dodge and tried to sting Adora again, but the Praetorian turned the thrust into another half turn and batted Scorpia's tail away with a crack. The move sent the Commander into a stagger. She recovered and pushed ahead, managing to tackle Adora. The blonde drove an elbow down once, twice, into Scorpia's back, which drew grunts from the muscular woman, but not much else. Scorpia lifted Adora, intending to drop her, sting her or crush her. Maybe all three.

Adora drove the shock prod into Scorpia's back. The large woman shuddered, her muscles clenching. She released Adora as soon as the prod was removed and she staggered back. But she was still upright. Teeth clenched, she charged again, but had to raise her claw to block a side swipe. The carapace made a nasty *crack* as the metal struck it and Scorpia hissed in pain. She pushed her other claw forward, intending to snatch Adora's weapon. But the Praetorian spun the weapon and knocked Scorpia's claw *up* , before she jammed the prod into the woman's gut. Scorpia juddered again and Adora spun, sending a back kick into the bigger woman to drive her further back. Scorpia fell on her ass, then rolled away, only to push herself up again. She charged once more, weathering another blow on her right claw, before she managed to grapple Adora's weapon. The pair tumbled and rolled. Fighting over the quarterstaff.

Adora caught movement in her peripheral as the pair stood, still wrestling. Her eyes widened, but Scorpia was too intent.

The Praetorian lifted herself up and, with both feet, kicked Scorpia *hard* . The move split the pair away and sent Scorpia tumbling backwards, Adora's weapon in hand, while Adora herself backflipped gracefully away.

Just as a gunshot range out and an anti armour round tore through the air where they'd both been fighting. Scorpia landed on her rear again, stunned as she looked between Adora and the mech that was clomping through the diminishing flames. She stared at the pilot in appalled shock, but the woman was waving at the controls, with a look of consternation on her face. The mech shuddered as the pilot wrestled with the machine.

Adora meanwhile was looking around her, assessing her options. More troops were moving around the fire and debris, cutting her off. The other mech was striding forward, while the damaged squid mech floated above. Menacingly.

The closer mech shuddered again and levelled its weapon at Adora. She tensed.

And then the mech was smashed off of its feet. The rifle it carried went flying. A second later, a metal fist smashed into the mech's body and sent it sprawling into the debris field.

Swift Wind moved with jerky motions, the shield now a thin, blueish film that covered its arrow-like body. There was no grace there. No finesse. Servos whined as the shuttle-cum-mech turned to Adora. The access hatch on its side opened up and Adora let out a breath. She felt *something* pulse within her, like a sudden wash of cool water over sweat-slicked skin. Refreshing and calming in a way that reminded you how *stretched* you had been before.

She sprinted, while all around soldiers stood in shock. A few shook themselves to action and opened fire, their shots going wide as they panicked. The squid mech dove down, but was stopped short as Swift Wind's mechanical arm shot out and caught it. There was the shriek of metal as the thing flailed at the larger mecha. Swift Wind shook and stumbled as Adora approached, while another gunshot sounded. The shield around the mecha fluttered again, the blue rippling and the lights on Swift Wind's frame dimming a

little. Adora drew closer, moving at a sprint that felt like slow-motion.

Swift Wind half turned and brought the squid-bot around, just as the second enemy mech took aim once more. This time, Swift Wind had the squid in a better position and the second round smashed into it instead.Adora's machine half turned, bringing the half wrecked squid back over its left shoulder, then it flung it at the enemy mech. The pilot tried to evade, but the hunk of tentacled scrap metal slammed into their machine and sent it sprawling. Swift Wind's arm went back just as Adora dove forward and it caught her, bringing her up and around to the access hatch.

A second later and Adora was back inside her home-away-from home. The hatch slammed shut and sealed as she slipped past the junction, to her left, the cockpit, to her right, the cramped bunk space, and the *core* embedded in the rear, near the engine access hatch.

The blue glow washed over her as she slid into the cockpit and sighed with relief. Readouts and dials came to life, many in the red. She shook her head - not time now. All around, troopers were firing blindly at the mecha in a panick. And she could see more of those side doors opening - more mechs incoming as troopers ran towards the entrances - pilots, perhaps, looking to reinforce.

She gripped the flight stick and took a chance. One of Swift Wind's weapons activated, an auto gun on the wrist of the machine. Soldiers shrieked and broke, abandoning firing lines to run back to the base interior, as Adora raked a harmless line of fire above their heads.

She turned to see one of the mechs had regained their footing and was trying to retrieve its weapon. No chance there. With a rapid movement, Adora sent Swift Wind forwards and *punched* the machine in its side, sending it sprawling again, its arm dented out of shape.

This was all a delay however. She could see more mechs emerging now, while behind them was a more deeper, darker glow. Something told her that there was something *worse* there. She felt it in Swift Winds core - a sense of *the enemy* . She didn't know what that meant, just that it was sending her internal gut reaction haywire.

The hangar doors above were still sealed. Time for intimidation 101. She sent Swift Wind over to the still-firing plasma torch. Its generator looked fairly beat up, but somehow still intact. She hefted the device and swept it across the hangar. The beam slashed across one of the emerging mechs, sending it tumbling backwards, a massive score across its front. The others seemed to remain in their bays for the moment, but she didn't have long - the torch was already dimming and its beam weakening.

Her hands flew across the controls and she redirected Swift Wind to aim the torch *up* . The hangar door began to melt, this time on the hatch itself. Metal slagged down as the plating glowed white hot.

Movement caught her eye and Adora swore as three mechs charged across the hangar, carrying rebar and debris rather than ranged weapons. Swift Wind leapt back, aided by a thrust from

jump jets as the first mech swung. The other two charged past, intent to impale Adora’s ship. She managed to deflect one and deliver a punch to the cockpit, sending the machine to the ground. The second scored a glancing blow and Adora rocked in her seat before she grappled the other mech. Swift Wind spun and flung the machine into the rearmost of the enemy mechs, before bent, scooped up the rebar and smashed ito down on the fallen mech, sending sparks flying as the generator on its back failed.

She spun and hurled the rebar across the room, where it pinned into the frame of one of the doors, partially blocking the mechs behind it. One began to wrestle with the steel bar, trying to pry it free. Adora cast her gaze around the room and heaved a sigh of relief as she saw, at the far end, a rack of munitions, untouched by the flames. She moved fast, hauled one of the missiles from the rack then hefted it like a javelin. The direct contact between her, Swift Wind and the weapon allowed her a mere moment to override its guidance system and the fuse within.

She threw it.

There was a moment of stillness, then the missile struck the weakened portion of the hangar bay door and it exploded *upwards* .

Adora whooped and kicked Swift Wind into gear. The mech crouched and leapt upwards, through the new hole. It scrambled and hauled itself through the molten gap and into the icy winds of the planet's atmosphere. Adora blinked and frowned as she realised the machine didn’t have enough energy recharged to shift and take flight. Certainly not enough to break orbit.

A flashed and the sudden blast of exploding ice drew her attention and she looked up to see a flight of fighters descending, bright red bolts lancing down and peppering the snow around the hangar. Clearly they'd been in a holding patrol and had swept in as soon as she'd emerged.

Adora made a decision - she needed time for Swift Wind to recharge, now that it wasn't maintaining a full block-shield. So, that meant she needed to *move* . Her trudge to the base had given her a chance to review the topography. She spun Swift Wind and forced the machine into a jog, arm raised as she fired off warning bursts into the air. The fighters peeled off, splitting as she fired up at them. A proximity alarm made her curse and she triggered a camera view on her console to view behind her.

Five mechs were clambering from the hole, and the rapidly opening hangar bay doors. A secondary hangar was opening and a troop transport was lifting off, along with a gunship.

Adora began to laugh, eyes wide and her smile feral.

The game was on.

Swift Wind move fast, now it was in the open, the eldritch device that gave it power augmenting servos way beyond the norm. The pursuing mecha seemed to have some sort of similarity, but not quite to Swift Winds extent. They weren't catching up, but *just* kept pace.

Snow exploded around her as the mechs fired and the gunship and troop transport moved into strafe her. They broke off as the fights came in for another run. She could see her destination ahead and grimace as Swift Wind stumbled,m a full salvo of blaster fire impacting his shields. Warning lights flashed as damage indicators lit up.

And then she was there - a gully, a long, long slope that slid down into a craggy valley.

Adora snarled and *leapt* . Swift Winds thrusters kicked in as it impacted the ice and snow and Adora began to guide the mecha down the slope, the machine's arms outstretched to balance.

Swift Wind began to *ski* down the ravine.

Behind her, the five mecha paused at the lip of the gully, then, one by one, then leapt into pursuit, slaloming down after her. The fighters shrieked overhead, then dove down, as the gully slid between towering crags of ice. Adora jerked and swerved as rounds smashed into the snow, sending tufts of it spurting up. Ice cracked as rounds smashed into glacier frost. Ahead, the slope morphed into ice-tunnels. Adora picked one and swerved into it, the light going green and blue as the tunnel looped between rock flows. Behind her the mechs followed, but had to split off.

One closed in fast, the machine bent to increase speed. Energy glowed around its feet - a rudimentary shield forming a smooth

enough surface to allow it to glide along. Adora squinted at her controls, snarled and spun Swift Wind as they went round a bend. The mech followed, only to be met by a hail of auto-cannon fire. The machine sparked and slipped, tumbling as it lost control, practically shearing apart at the speed it was going.

Adora turned her mech back, just as the tunnel opened up again onto a wide slope. Four mechs emerged alongside her, while five fighters dove down. Adora raised her arms (Swift Wind's arms) and fired. The fighters split, but one was clipped and tumbled down. The mechs to her right tried to split, but one over compensated and smashed into an ice pillar, before it went careening off, to tumble down the mountainside. The fighter impacted in a fireball, triggering an avalanche off the side of the mountain, away from Adora and her pursuers.

Adora split and went under an ice bridge, where the slope arched and split, before it rejoined. One mech went over, trying to fire down at her, while the other two closed in. One seemed to be carrying a repeater weapon, which looked like it had been repurposed from a fighter. The snow fountained up as the thing fired in bursts, trying to drive Adora to slow down by weaving to avoid the fire.

Instead she slid up the side of the gulley and Swift Wind arced back and over so it landed behind the mech, the second one still hanging back, while the third continued along, above the gully. The fighters were behind now, firing down.

Adora made Swift Wind crouch again and grappled the mech. The weight shift almost made them tumble, but Adora pushed away, snatching the repeater weapon away and firing it point blank into

the mech as they continued down the mountain. The cockpit exploded and the machine tumbled away, just slag, as Adora continued to ski *backwards* , firing up at the fighters. They tried to peel away, but two were sliced apart by the sudden AA fire. The weapon whined as it ran dry and Adora threw it at her second pursuer. The machine ducked it and Adora spun her mech as the pursuit led into a forest of crags.

A roar announced the gunship's return and it wove between spires, firing its turrets down at Adora. Rock and ice splintered. Adora could see on her sensors that the fighters had peeled away to come in ahead, clearly aiming to hose her down in a bottle-neck.

She wasn't falling for that and pushed up, igniting her thrusters. Swift Wind had enough to propel itself onto the upper adjacent slope, just as the fighters screamed in to strafe the narrow gully. The pursuing mech tried to avoid it, but was chewed apart by friendly fire, just as Adora landed on the higher slope, next to the final machine. It turned, the pilot shocked. Adora activated Swift Winds wrist beam, the same thing she'd used to slice apart drones way back when this had all started, and sliced the machine's leg off. It began to tumble, but Swift Wind caught the machine, and using their speed, spun and launched it up ward.

The gunship banked around an ice spire, trying to reacquire its target after breaking off for the fighters, only to be met by a flying mecha. The pilot yelled in shock and hauled to bank away, which meant the mech only smashed off a port side wing and engine block, which sent the gunship into a spiral towards the mountain side.

Adora glanced at her energy readings and bit her lip, as, ahead, the mountain began to steepen into a more sheer pivot as the glacier ran out of… glacier.

The troop transport roared overhead, turning sharply, revealing an open hatch and soldiers ready to fire. A mounted gun whirred to life.

The mountain ended as Adora leapt once more. Plasma fire rained into the snow behind Swift Wind as the mech passed below the gunship. It spun, trying to track the mech as Swift Wind tumbled down, into the mist below.

The fighters came around the mountain, in a high arc ready for another attack run. The troop transport wavered, as the mist swirled below.

Then, with a flash of blue, Swift Wind rose up, fast. A blade flashed and the transport tumbled away, warning alarms blaring and troops clinging on for dear life as a section of its tail tumbled away. The ship managed to right itself and angled for an emergency landing on the mountain, trailing smoke, while Swift Wind reoriented itself and shot across the sky. The fighters tried to break, but one found itself bereft a wing, causing the pilot to eject. The second found that it had a rather dogged pursuer as it dove into the forest of craggy spires, jinking between them as the mech darted between them, far more agile and *swift* .

The pilot tried to bak as the mecha suddenly darted in front of him, suddenly presenting itself as a target.

Except it *wasn't.* The pilot stared in horror as the mech accelerated away, slicing away at the icespires, which began to tumble down. The fighter pulled up, only for a shadow to fall across it before it vanished in a fiery blossom.

Adora panted as she brought Swift Wind into a hover. Sweat beaded across her forehead as she finally tore off the Horde helmet and tossed it away. Her readouts were flashing red - no shields, barely enough for weapons, *just* enough for flight. She cackled in relief and vague mania, then patted the console, "Well done… I think… it's time to go home. Without being all showy?"

She angled the ship down, then dove hugging the ground, before she then shifted Swift Wind into shuttle form. The dive and momentum let her push it up and up and up. She felt the craft rattle and rumble and hoped it hadn't suffered too much. She didn't fancy trying to survive on the surface of the ice rock evading the Horde.

Swift Wind shook as they hit the atmosphere limit. And then, like the breaking of a fever, she felt the weightlessness of space embrace them both. Twinkling in the distance she could see the gathered fleet, with several distant lights already moving to intercept. She pivoted Swift Wind and sighed - enough for a short jump. She'd have to be evasive for a bit.

But she could do that. And maybe cause a bit of mayhem to keep the Horde distracted before she went… back. Back to her friends. She smiled to herself. Things were looking up. For the first time in a long while. With a whine, the core lit up a bright blue and Swift

Wind vanished into the black, leaving a trail of fighters and confused Horde naval personnel behind.

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Catra seethed as she surveyed the smoldering wreckage of the hangar. She didn't trust herself to look at the Governor, who stood silently next to her.The small amount of relief she'd had around Adora had morphed into a cold rage again, coupled with a sense of resentment and terror.

Scorpia sat on a crate while a medic tended to her wounds. The woman was fairly beat up, but seemed to be putting a brave face on things.

Hordak looked around and growled, "Vexing."

"Governor, I can…"

"Silence, *Commodore* ." Catra's jaw fairly clicked as the man spoke. When he turned to her, he had an irritated set to his bat-like features, "This is… an appalling failure. But hardly one I am surprised by."

Catra straightened and rolled her shoulders, "Sir, we aren't…"

Hordak turned and snarled down at Catra, "Aren't *what* ? Competent? Capable? *Equipped* ? This is… an embarrassment," he straightened and his snarl shifted into a knowing sneer, But then again you are none of those things. Competent, capable or equipped… to handle a Praetorian. Only the most hardened of facilities are built to do so." Catra blanched at Hordak's nonchalant tone. He looked around and shook his head, "It's shoddy. Clearly this one was attempting to sabotage your project. And trying to frame the local yokels in doing so. Your forces are… inadequate. I can hardly fault you for the inability to tackle a weapon designed to topple whole garrisons."

Catra blinked her fear turning to surprise, "A… Praetorian, sir? You're, um… you're sure?"

"I recognise the style. And your security footage all but confirms it. The style, the fact it was a *single* infiltrator. But shoddy."

Now the magicat was *confused* , "But… they're Imperial agents… did…" she decided to lean into ignorance, "Did one go rogue?"

Hordak snorted derisively, "They do not go rogue. We have failsafes for that. If this one *was* rogue, your soldiers would be *dead* . No, I think one of my… peers… is attempting to snatch *my* glorious project from under my nose," he sneered, "Rank amateur."

This was just getting weird. Catra coughed, "You're…. Sure, sir?"

“Why do you think I am here, Commodore? This.. hick speck of a system holds no interest save for *two* things. The find and the potential technology in the planetoids. We have lost *one* . And that galls me, but… I am not surprised. To punish you would be fruitless,” his cold demeanour did shift to irritation, “But this was *unacceptable* . Instead I will use this as a *lesson* . You must be *vigilant* . And you will set some *examples* among your… ill prepared troops.”

“Yes sir.” Catra nodded, her stance brittle, her tail practically fluffed in a mix of embarrassment and fear. Hordak chuckled humourlessly and waved at the mechs that were trudging around the hangar. A few looked battered and damaged, but were already being repaired.

“It was an adequate demonstration of the progress made. Combat mechs with agility, versatility and adaptability. Even a basic pilot can use them? Commodore… I am a man of *engineering* . But you have *lost* our source of information … If this is a prototype…”

“Oh those are just trial runs, barely prototypes. Hey! Who are you?” Catra mentally face palmed on as Entrapta seemed to pop out of nowhere. Her final squid mech cradled her like some malignant spider, “OHHH Are you here to see the PROJECT?”

Hordak blinked in surprise at Entrapta and scowled, “And you are?”

“Chief Engineer Entrapta! Her, is that a personal shield belt? Wow, I thought those were Imperial family *only* … waiiiit are you the

Governor? You're… bluer than I expected, note to self, reschedule maintenance exercises for dignitary visit."

"Entrapta," hissed Catra, "Focus. Did the project get… damaged?"

"Um… no. But wow, I got some AMAZING readings. I mean, amazing. Sympathetic. And the Primary unit we lost? Well, frankly, we learned all we could. I just wanted to carve it up, as, well, you can learn SO MUCH MORE when you take things apart."

Hordak glowered at Entrapta, "Cease your prattling. Explain."

"Oh, well, that thing was basically a really badly grafted together engine and an antique piece ship. I'm surprised it managed to break orbit! And, well, these things are.. Well, they're exoskeletons with a *tiny* fragment of tech in them," Entrapta beamed, "They're experiments… but… well… let me SHOW you!"

The floor shook as one of the side doors hissed open, locks disengaging. Hordak's scowl faded as he watched something *towering* stride from the side-hangar, into the wreck of the room. He blinked and a slow, thin smile split his face, but it fell away, "If this is so *impressive* , why did it not enter the fray?"

Entrapta rubbed her hands, eyes sparkling, "It TRIED."

Hordak stilled and looked at her, "Explain."

"It *wanted* to. I think. We had it locked in its gantry. Along with the main unit. This is just the first one, the rest aren't… finished. But they all *tried* to move. Fascinating. This one is… just the first."

Hordak gazed up at the machine. It *looked* like a mech. Bipedal, bulky chest frame with a cockpit at the top. It topped out at forty feet tall, dwarfing the other mecha around it. It was oddly coloured, with a blue-ish sheen, that seemed to shift to purple. The cockpit was bone white, though, and it didn't seem to be anything to do with paint. Green, glowing cabling threaded at its joints.

"What is it?"

Hordak watched as thin fingers on the machine flexed, almost imperceptibly. Entrapta clapped her hands, "Some sort of… nascent automotive behaviours. A sort of… Friend or Foe system based on the salvaged tech. I think, no I'm *sure* I have it mapped out. The only thing we're lacking is… a compatible pilot."

Hordak and Catra stared at her. Hordak's frown deepened, "That will need… extrapolation."

"It's why I didn't… release it. With the attack, I mean. I wasn't sure what the end stage would be, we can control remotely, but there was a danger there if the attacker subverted it. It was about to launch anyway, when the,... attacker managed to get away. But

uh…" she glanced nervously at Catra, "But Weaver came online and interfaced, putting it into a holding state. She advised that it needs a pilot. Technically anyone will do but… apparently the better someone can interface with it, the easier to pilot it it'll be."

Hordak's frown didn't shift but he snorted, "Your shackled AI that I was told was down *interfaced* ?"

Entrapta shrugged expansively, "I KNOW! Fascinating. She isn't… entirely responsive still. But she managed to explain that before 5K31-T0R here broke the scaffolding it was in!"

Hordak stared at the mech and cocked his head, "A pilot, you say. Commodore. I want this thing tested. I want to see what it can do. Find me someone. Before my rivals capitalise on their ill gotten gains."

"HA! That won't happen," Cackled Entrapta, "I mean, where else can they take a broken, half drained scraphead? We can track it. We did it before."

"Then we have the ideal target for a test run," Hordak smiled thinly, "An excellent suggestion, Chief Engineer. Commodore… you have your orders."

"Yes sir," Catra swallowed and shot Entrapta a glance, but the Engineer was staring up at the mech, seemingly lost in wonder. The magicat stalked away, pausing to cock her head at Scorpia.

The Scorponi woman smiled weakly at her and heaved a weary sigh.

"She saved me."

Catra blinked, "Huh?"

Scorpia shot a worried look at the stomping mechs, "One of those… it shot at me. Ad… the Praetorian… she saved me. Kicked me clear."

The magicat's mouth opened, then shut. She swallowed and frowned. In her mind her brain was running overtime. The mech had tried to kill Scorpia? "The pilot took the shot? What, someone did a risk judgement and thought killing the threat was worth your life?" she clenched her fists at the thought and tried to suppress the shame that, at one stage she'd have made a similar decision with little worry.

Scorpia shook her head, "No, the pilot seemed confused. The mech,.. Did it itself."

Catra scoffed, "They haven't got an onboard network or AI. They're too small. Barely any targeting systems…." Catra stared across the hangar, an uneasy feeling tugging at her. She needed to talk to Entrapta. She managed to nod at Scorpia, "Get rested up. The Governor wants to see what these new toys can do."

Scorpia studied her friend, “You know what that means.”

The magicat winced and nodded shakily, “I’ll work it out.”

She spun on her heel and stalked from the hangar, while a security camera lens tracked her movement. It zoomed in, then panned back up to focus on the towering mech. As soon as the camera focused on the machine its fingers flexed again, but barely.

As if… in anticipation.

Chapter End Notes

I was tempted to split this in two and post some of it as a one shot follow on as if it were a two parter. But I feel this works a contained story and we see the setup.

Did you catch the references? We're gonna go MONSTER OF THE WEEK voltron style soon!

Also, this Hordak is less... volatile than canon (Not stranded and desperate, this is Hordak as I imagine he was BEFORE he got lost on Etheria - confident, a solid leader, ruthless but not impatient and frustrated... but definitely arrogant)

As ever, let me know your thoughts! And thank you for your patience - this one has been on me for a bit to get done and has stopped me being able to write ANYTHING ELSE!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!